Section A Exam Rubric

Mark	Expected qualities
9–10	• Demonstrates a close and perceptive reading of the text, considering complexities of its ideas, concerns and values explored through the structure of the text and its language • Demonstrates a clear understanding of the implications of the topic, using an appropriate strategy for dealing with it, and exploring its complexity from the basis of the text • Develops a cogent, controlled and well-substantiated discussion using precise and expressive language
8	• Demonstrates a thoughtful reading of the text, exploring its ideas, concerns and values through a discussion of the structure of the text and its language • Demonstrates an understanding of the implications of the topic, exploring it from the basis of the text • Develops a detailed, substantiated and coherent discussion using language fluently and confidently
7	• Demonstrates detailed knowledge of the text throughout, including some of its ideas, concerns and values by appropriately acknowledging aspects of the structure of the text and its language • Understands the topic, developing a sustained and well-supported response • Develops an organised piece of writing using language accurately and appropriately
6	• Demonstrates a clear knowledge of the text, including some elements of its ideas, concerns and values and some awareness of structure and language • Develops a response to the topic, supported by appropriate evidence from the text • Presents a generally organised piece of writing using language that is mostly accurate and appropriate
5	• Demonstrates an adequate knowledge of the text and makes some reference to its ideas, concerns and values

Mark	Expected qualities
	• Presents a response that shows an understanding of the topic referring to evidence from the text • Presents a piece of writing that communicates adequately, displaying some elements of organisation
4	• Demonstrates basic knowledge of the text with limited reference to ideas, concerns and values • Presents a response that shows some understanding of the topic • Shows adequate expression and language control
3	• Shows a familiarity with the text • Shows a limited awareness of the topic • Shows basic expression and language control
1–2	• Shows limited familiarity with the text • Shows a very limited awareness of the topic • Uses language that is not always clear
0	• Shows no knowledge of the text and/or no attempt to engage with the topic and/or only minimal control of language

Section B Exam Rubric

Mark(s)	Expected Qualities
9–10	• Demonstrates insightful consideration of the ideas raised by the title and stimulus in connection with a Framework of Ideas • Creates a cohesive text with an explicit purpose(s) and an appropriate voice • Demonstrates sophisticated control of language and text structure(s), that makes rich use of vocabulary and language features

Mark(s)	Expected Qualities
8	• Demonstrates an astute exploration of the ideas raised by the title and stimulus in connection with a Framework of Ideas • Creates a coherent text with an explicit purpose(s) and an appropriate voice • Demonstrates confident control of language and text structure(s), that makes thoughtful use of vocabulary and language features
7	• Demonstrates a detailed connection to the ideas raised by the title and stimulus related to a Framework of Ideas • Creates a coordinated text with a clear purpose(s) and an appropriate voice • Demonstrates sound control of language and text structure(s), that makes clear use of vocabulary and language features
6	• Develops a clear connection to the ideas raised by the title and stimulus with reference to a Framework of Ideas • Creates a connected text with a clear purpose(s) and an appropriate voice • Demonstrates clear control of language and text structure(s), makes effective use of vocabulary and language features
5	• Develops an adequate connection to the ideas raised by the title and stimulus with reference to a Framework of Ideas • Creates an organised text that is linked to a purpose(s) and has an appropriate voice • Demonstrates adequate control of language and text structure(s), that makes some use of vocabulary and language features
4	• Shows a basic connection to the ideas raised by the title and stimulus • Shows some connection to a purpose(s) and some awareness of voice • Shows basic control of language and text structure(s), that makes simple use of vocabulary and language features

Mark(s)	Expected Qualities
3	• Shows limited connection to the ideas raised by the title and stimulus • Shows limited awareness of purpose or appropriate voice • Shows limited control of language and structure
1–2	• Shows little or no apparent connection to ideas raised by the title and stimulus • Shows little awareness of the purpose(s) of their text • Uses language that is not always clear
0	• Shows no knowledge of the task and/or no attempt to engage with the task

Section C Exam Rubric

Mark(s)	Expected Qualities
9–10	• Demonstrates a perceptive understanding of contention, the development of argument(s) as constructed in the text and the point of view expressed • Demonstrates sophisticated insight into the ways in which written and spoken language and visuals complement the argument(s) and are used to persuade the intended audience • Uses sophisticated and precise language
8	• Demonstrates a thoughtful understanding of contention, the development of argument(s) as constructed in the text and the point of view expressed • Demonstrates sound insight into the ways in which the written and spoken language and visuals work together to build the argument(s) and persuade the intended audience • Uses language confidently
7	• Demonstrates detailed understanding of contention, argument(s) presented in the text and the point of view expressed

Mark(s)	Expected Qualities
	• Demonstrates insight into the ways in which the written and spoken language and visuals in the text are used to persuade the intended audience • Uses fluent expression
6	• Demonstrates a clear understanding of contention, the argument(s) presented in the text and the point of view expressed • Demonstrates some awareness of the ways in which the written and spoken language and visuals in the text are used to persuade the intended audience • Uses competent expression
5	• Demonstrates adequate understanding of contention, the argument(s) presented and the point of view expressed • Demonstrates basic awareness of the ways in which the written and spoken language and visuals in the text are used to persuade the intended audience • Uses language adequately
4	• Demonstrates a basic understanding of the contention, the argument(s) and point of view expressed • Describes the ways in which written and spoken language and visuals are used to persuade an audience • Uses basic language
3	• Shows a limited knowledge of the argument(s) or point of view • Shows a limited knowledge of the ways in which written and spoken language and visuals are used • Attempts basic language
1–2	• Shows little understanding of the material • Shows only minimal knowledge of the task • Uses language that is not always clear

Mark(s)	Expected Qualities
0	• Shows no understanding of the requirements of the task

Examiners do not read your essay the way a friendly teacher does – they read it in passes, testing it against the criteria. Knowing the passes lets you write for them.

The Six Passes

First, the scope audit: the topic is broken into its explicit and implicit parts, including modifying words ("unrelenting cruelty", not just "cruelty") and both halves of a double-barrelled prompt. A dimension you never address keeps you out of the 8–10 range. Second, the summary filter: every sentence is silently sorted into retelling, explaining, or analysing how the author constructs meaning – and if retelling dominates, the essay cannot reach the upper band no matter how fluent it is. Third, the topic-sentence thread: conceptual topic sentences that build a progressive argument separate 9–10 essays from 7–8 essays that give three parallel examples of one idea. Fourth, the authorial hand: markers look for sentences whose subject is the author ("Jackson constructs…", "Weir juxtaposes…") – writing about characters as though they are real people is a mid-band signature. Fifth, evidence gravity: quotes that stand alone as their own sentences read mid-band; short quotes woven into your own grammar, drawn from across the whole text, read upper-band. Sixth, the gap analysis: the difference between your mark and the next band is always something specific and nameable – which is why good feedback tells you what was missing, not just what was there.

What the Bands Feel Like

A 5 is relevant but basic: simple structure, simple vocabulary, evidence that supports plot points. A 7 is clear and detailed, uses evidence effectively, but stays at the level of what the text shows rather than how and why it was built that way. A 9 or 10 is sophisticated and perceptive: it reframes the topic conceptually, treats the text as a construction, uses precise metalanguage correctly, and integrates evidence so smoothly the quotation marks could be removed without breaking the sentence.

Section-Specific Traps

In Section A, a contention that simply agrees or disagrees without a bigger conceptual claim caps the essay in the middle band, and ignoring the text's social and historical values keeps the

top band out of reach. In Section B, a competent story that never engages the Framework's ideas sits mid-band, as do clichéd premises and unearned endings – while adapted echoes of your mentor texts signal studied craft. In Section C, "the readers" is a mid-band audience; the upper band names who the writer targets and what they are being positioned to think, feel and do. Naming a technique without explaining its function for that specific audience is label-picking, and it caps the analysis no matter how many techniques you spot. Track the argument's arc and tonal shifts; treat any visual as part of the argument, not a separate exhibit.